Such was the effect of his talk that, even in a small town, VOC was able to sell a few hundred shares. By now, the CID was taking serious note of him and considered his ‘utterances … seditious’.[86] On 2 April, VOC spoke at Tirunelveli on the advantages of investing in SSNCo.[87] In early June 1907, he delivered a lecture on ‘Swadeshism and Boycott’ on which topic he held forth ‘vehemently and enthusiastically’.[88]

In July 1907, G. Subramania Iyer was in Tuticorin, at the invitation of VOC. Pandithurai Thevar too shared the platform.[89] G. Subramania Iyer delivered lectures in Tirunelveli again in August 1907, exhorting people to take shares.[90] From Tuticorin he travelled to Kovilpatti, Sattur and Virudupatti and delivered public lectures urging people to take shares. At Virudupatti, VOC was also present, and he spoke as well.[91]

At the end of August 1907, VOC, accompanied by S.D. Krishna Aiyangar, went to Salem on a subscription-raising tour, spending several days giving public talks. Prominent citizens of Salem such as C. Vijayaraghavachari and B.V. Narasimhaiah and others welcomed them with much fanfare.[92]

This is the scattered information that we have gleaned from newspaper reports and police intelligence and therefore his itinerary is far from complete. At this time, VOC was also shuttling between Bombay and Tuticorin organizing the purchase of the steamers. Amid this busy schedule, he travelled widely giving inspired talks and urging the common people to invest in the company.

A Team Effort

If VOC was taking the lead, others too were giving their best.

Despite his royal lineage, Pandithurai Thevar did not hesitate to get his feet dirty. In July 1907, on a visit to Thanjavur, he lectured at the Besant Lodge—with prominent men of the town such as Abraham Pandithar (a practitioner of indigenous medicine, entrepreneur and pioneering musicologist) and T. Sadasiva Rao in the audience—asking people to start